

FIKA — Stage 1: Empathy and Psychology

App Concept and Context

Fika is a child-only student transport service designed specifically for Cape Town parents of primary and high school learners. The service operates a vetted fleet of company owned vehicles that run fixed routes across different areas of Cape Town Brackenfell, Bellville, and surrounding areas. Parents register, add their children, select their school area, and get assigned to a route. The company approves applications, assigns a driver, and parents pay a monthly fee.

The app has two interfaces one for parents and one for drivers. Both sides of the app serve the same core purpose from different angles: getting children to school and home safely, with full visibility and accountability at every step.

The app is named Fika a Swahili word meaning to arrive. Swahili is my home language and family language. The name was chosen intentionally. The entire product exists to answer one question a parent asks every school morning: did my child arrive?

Business Model and Trust Foundation

Fika is not a gig economy platform. It is a structured transport company with employed, tested, and vetted drivers operating company owned vehicles. Every driver undergoes a driving assessment and full background check before being assigned a route. This is not a person who decided to start driving — it is a business with professional standards, accountability structures, and legal employment contracts.

This distinction is critical for parent trust. In South Africa, parents already use private school transport — but trust is built through word of mouth and personal referrals. A neighbour recommends a driver. A friend vouches for someone. That system works but it does not scale and it has no accountability layer beyond personal reputation.

Fika takes that existing cultural trust model and formalises it. The vetting, the background checks, the driving assessments, and the company structure replace word of mouth with institutional accountability. Parents are not trusting a stranger — they are trusting a company with legal responsibility for their child's safety.

All vehicles are company owned and return to the company yard after all children have been dropped off. Drivers do not take vehicles home. This means the fleet is company controlled at all times — a detail that significantly strengthens parent confidence during onboarding.

Fleet Tracking and Driver Accountability

All Fika vehicles are tracked via GPS at all times. Because the vehicles belong to the company, this is standard fleet management practice — legally and ethically straightforward. The tracking serves three distinct purposes:

For parents: Real time visibility of their child's journey from pickup to drop-off.

For the company: Monitoring of fleet usage, route adherence, and driver behaviour throughout the working day.

For accountability: If a driver deviates from their assigned route during working hours — whether during a pickup run or after all children have been dropped off — that data is recorded. Drivers are aware of this as a condition of employment.

This feature protects parents, protects the company, and protects drivers who do their job correctly. The same data that reassures a parent is the same data that clears a driver of a false accusation.

The Core Emotional Insight

Before any research, wireframes, or features — the emotional foundation of Fika was identified through empathy work.

When a parent puts their child in the Fika car for the very first time and the car drives away, they do not feel relief. They do not feel trust. Those emotions come later, after the app has proven itself repeatedly over time.

What they actually feel in that first moment is controlled anxiety. They made the decision. They paid the money. They told themselves it is safe. But the car is gone and their child is in it.

This means Fika's design challenge is not registration, payment, or onboarding alone. The real challenge is:

How does Fika convert first-time anxiety into earned trust, one trip at a time?

The answer is visibility. Every pickup confirmation, every arrived notification, every timestamped drop-off is one moment of anxiety converted into relief. The app does not create trust before the first trip. It builds trust during and after every trip that follows.

Empathy Map — Parent

User: A working Cape Town parent. One or more primary or high school children. Currently relying on walking, public transport, or lifts to get their child to school.

SAYS

- "I can't always be there to fetch them"
- "The taxi is cheap but I don't feel safe sending them alone"
- "I just need to know they got there"
- "If anything happened I would never forgive myself"

THINKS

- What if the driver is not who he says he is
- What if my child doesn't get on the car
- What if there's an accident
- Is this worth the monthly cost
- What if I can't reach my child and the app goes down

DOES

- Calls the child repeatedly until they confirm arrival
- Asks a neighbour or relative to watch out
- Takes time off work to fetch them personally
- Relies on older siblings to accompany younger ones
- Asks friends and neighbours to recommend trusted drivers through word of mouth

FEELS

- Chronic low level anxiety every school morning
- Guilt when they cannot be present
- Helplessness when they have no visibility
- Temporary relief only when the child confirms they arrived safely

PAINS

- No reliable affordable child-only transport option exists
- Public transport exposes children to adults with bad intentions
- Walking routes are unpredictable and unmonitored
- Communication depends entirely on the child remembering to call
- Word of mouth referrals work but do not scale and have no formal accountability

GAINS

- A moving dot on a map confirming their child is safe

- Notification when child is picked up and dropped off
 - A driver vetted and employed by a trusted company
 - One less thing to carry mentally every single day
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Empathy Map — Driver

User: A vetted Fika driver. Cape Town based. Responsible for 4 to 8 children per route per day across multiple schools.

SAYS

- "I dropped the child off, I can't control what happens after"
- "The parent never told me she wasn't coming today"
- "I have other children waiting, I can't sit here"
- "I've been doing this job properly and now they're blaming me"

THINKS

- What if a parent accuses me of something I didn't do
- I need proof that I did my job correctly
- Why do parents only communicate when there's a problem
- If I lose this job I lose my income

DOES

- Calls the parent when a child doesn't come out
- Waits longer than he should hoping the child appears
- Takes personal notes or screenshots to protect himself
- Drives the route from memory after months on the job

FEELS

- Unprotected when accusations come without evidence
- Frustrated by poor communication from parents
- Anxious about being held responsible for things outside his control
- Proud when the route runs smoothly and all children are safe

PAINS

- No formal record of pickups and drop-offs
- Dependent on parents communicating proactively about absences
- Route changes or absences discovered only on arrival
- Blamed for situations that started after his responsibility ended

GAINS

- A clear daily manifest of who is being picked up and where
 - Automatic notification when a parent marks a child absent
 - Timestamped confirmation when each child is collected and delivered
 - Protection through data if an accusation is ever made
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Key Insight Connecting Both Users

The parent needs visibility to feel safe. The driver needs records to feel protected. The same data solves both problems simultaneously.

Every pickup confirmation, every drop-off timestamp, every absence notification flows both ways. The parent receives it as reassurance. The driver receives it as protection. One action. Two users. Multiple problems solved.

Cognitive Biases in Play

1. Familiarity Bias Parents already know Uber and Bolt. They will arrive at Fika expecting the same mental model — map, moving dot, ETA. If Fika deviates from that pattern without good reason, parents will feel confused and lose trust immediately. *Design implication: The tracking screen must feel instantly familiar. Not copied — but recognisable.*

2. Paradox of Choice During onboarding a parent is already anxious. If registration asks too many questions at once — number of children, school names, areas, payment details, emergency contacts — they will abandon before completing. *Design implication: Onboarding must be broken into small committed steps. One decision at a time.*

3. Anchoring Bias The first number a parent sees anchors their perception of value. If the monthly price appears before trust is established, it feels expensive. If it appears after they have seen driver vetting, safety features, and real time tracking — the same number feels completely reasonable. *Design implication: Price is revealed late in onboarding, after value is demonstrated.*

4. Loss Aversion Parents are not paying for convenience. They are paying to avoid loss — specifically the loss of their child's safety. Fear of something going wrong is a stronger motivator than the promise of something going right. *Design implication: Fika's messaging focuses on what parents no longer have to worry about, not just what they gain.*

5. Von Restorff Effect On the driver's daily manifest, if all children look identical — same text, same size, same weight — nothing stands out. But if one child has a medical note, a gate code,

or a special instruction, it needs to visually separate from the rest. *Design implication: Critical child information must be visually distinct on the driver's screen.*

6. Peak End Rule Parents will judge the entire Fika experience based on two moments — the most intense moment and the last moment. The most intense moment is when the car drives away the first time. The last moment is when they receive the arrived notification. *Design implication: The arrived notification is not just a system message. It is the moment a parent exhales. It must feel warm, clear, and immediate.*

UX Thinking Loop

OBSERVE Parents in Cape Town call their child repeatedly every school morning hoping for a reply. They rely on neighbours, older siblings, or taking time off work to ensure safety. They use public transport knowing it is unsafe because no affordable alternative exists. When parents do find a solution, it comes through word of mouth — a neighbour recommends a driver, a friend vouches for someone. That system works but it does not scale and has no formal accountability layer. Drivers in similar informal services work with no digital record of their routes, carrying the mental load of remembering every address. When something goes wrong they have no evidence to protect themselves. There is currently no structured, app-based, child-only transport solution in South Africa built specifically for this problem.

DEFINE Cape Town parents of primary and high school learners struggle to trust their children's safety travelling to and from school — because there is no affordable, child-only, trustworthy transport solution that gives them real visibility into whether their child arrived safely.

DESIGN A dual interface mobile app. Parent side built around visibility, trust, and simplicity. Driver side built around efficiency, accountability, and protection.

Emotional goal of every screen:

- Parent screens must feel — calm, clear, in control
- Driver screens must feel — organised, fast, protected

Every feature that does not serve those emotional goals gets cut or reconsidered.

TEST Four questions Fika's design must answer in usability testing:

- Can a first time parent complete registration without confusion or abandonment?
 - Does the parent feel reassured the moment they see the tracking screen?
 - Can a driver complete a full route — pickups, navigation, confirmations — without looking at the screen for more than 3 seconds at a time?
 - Does the arrived notification land as warm and trustworthy or cold and robotic?
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Problem Statement

Cape Town parents of primary and high school learners struggle to trust their children's safety travelling to and from school — because there is no affordable, child-only, trustworthy transport solution that gives them real visibility into whether their child arrived safely.

FIKA — Stage 2: UX Research

The Dollar 1 vs Dollar 100 Principle

Fixing a problem during research costs almost nothing. Fixing the same problem after the app is built costs everything. This is why Stage 2 exists before a single screen is drawn.

Stage 1 told us what we think parents and drivers feel. Stage 2 tells us what they actually feel. Those two things are not always the same.

Research Goals

Before choosing a method you need to know exactly what questions your research must answer. For Fika there are two user types so there are two sets of questions.

Parent Research Goals

- What is their current school transport situation
- What specifically triggers their anxiety around child safety
- Have they used informal transport before and what was that experience
- What would make them trust a service enough to register their child
- What would make them abandon the app during onboarding
- What does a successful morning look like to them

Driver Research Goals

- What does a typical school run look like day to day
 - What problems come up most frequently on the job
 - How do they currently handle communication with parents
 - What would make their job easier and less stressful
 - What does being falsely accused feel like and has it happened
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Research Method

Method chosen: Qualitative user interviews

Fika is a product built around emotion, trust, and safety. Numbers and data cannot capture why a parent feels anxious or why a driver feels unprotected. Qualitative interviews surface the human truth underneath the behaviour — which is exactly what this stage requires.

Participants

- 1 parent participant matching the target user profile
- 1 driver participant matching the target service provider profile

Format One on one conversational interviews. No scripts. Scenario based questions. Follow the emotion. Ask why repeatedly.

Parent Interview — Nomsa D.

Participant profile Name: Nomsa D. Age: 34 Occupation: Admin clerk, Bellville Children: Two. A daughter in Grade 4 and a son in Grade 8. Current transport: Daughter walks with a neighbour's child. Son takes the minibus taxi alone. Device: Android user

Interview Summary

Nomsa wakes at 5:30 every morning to prepare herself before her children wake up. She leaves the house by 7:00 to catch her taxi to work. On some mornings she is already gone before her son Liam has left the house. Her daughter Amahle walks to school with a neighbour's child.

Her area in Bellville has men who gather near the taxi rank in the mornings. Liam is 14 but small for his age. Nomsa worries about robbery and intimidation near the rank. Amahle is 9 — two small girls walking together does not feel safe but Nomsa has no other option currently.

Her single biggest anxiety point is sitting at work with her phone off, not knowing if her children arrived safely. That feeling sits with her the entire day.

She has explored alternatives through word of mouth — a colleague recommended a lady in Parow who drives children to school, but the geography did not work. A man in her street offered to take Liam for R400 a month but Nomsa could not bring herself to trust him. No contract. No company. No accountability if something went wrong.

When asked what a service like Fika would mean for her she went quiet before answering. Her response became the most important insight of the entire interview.

"It would make me feel like a better mother. Like I did something right for my children even though I cannot be there with them." — Nomsa D., research participant

Parent Research Findings

Finding 1 Word of mouth is the current system but has geographic limitations.

Recommendations only work within a neighbourhood. A trusted driver in Parow cannot help a parent in Bellville.

Finding 2 Informal drivers feel untrustworthy without formal structure behind them. A neighbour offering transport is not the same as a company offering transport. The difference is accountability.

Finding 3 Price is a real constraint. Affordability is non negotiable. Whatever Fika costs it must make sense for a single income household. Affordable does not mean cheap — it means fair for what you earn.

Finding 4 Parents want institutional accountability. A name, a face, a number, something formal and registered. A verbal agreement between neighbours offers no protection if something goes wrong.

Finding 5 Reliability is non negotiable. Every morning. Not maybe. The informal system breaks when the driver decides to stop — sometimes with two weeks notice, sometimes with none. Parents need guaranteed consistency.

Finding 6 Legal accountability and insurance matter deeply. A registered company signals seriousness and protection in a way an individual never can. If something happens to a child the parent needs someone they can hold responsible.

Finding 7 A single notification that the child arrived safely would be emotionally transformative for a working parent. Not a fancy feature — just a message that says they are there. That is enough to change the entire emotional experience of a school morning.

Finding 8 Fika is not selling transport. It is not selling tracking. It is selling the feeling of being a good parent despite impossible circumstances. That is the core emotional value of the product.

Driver Interview — Sipho M.

Participant profile Name: Sipho M. Age: 29 Occupation: Informal school transport driver, Brackenfell area Experience: 2 years driving children to school independently Vehicle: His own car, a 2018 Toyota Corolla Children he transports: 6 children across 3 schools How he started: Word of mouth through his church community

Interview Summary

Sipho plans his route the night before because there is no time to think in the morning. He picks up across three areas — Brackenfell North, Brackenfell Central, and Protea Heights — serving three different schools. First school starts at 7:30 which means all children must be in the car by 7:00.

His biggest daily stress is not the driving. It is the uncertainty. Children not ready when he arrives. Parents who knew the night before that their child would not attend but said nothing. Every unnecessary trip costs him fuel from his own pocket with no reimbursement.

He described an incident involving a child named Kavelo that became the most significant moment of the entire research phase. Sipho dropped Kavelo at school and watched him walk through the gate. That afternoon Kavelo's mother called in a panic — the school said he was not in class. She accused Sipho of not taking him to school. For three hours Sipho had nothing to show her. No timestamp. No record. Just his word against a scared mother's fear.

Kavelo had left school through a hole in the fence during break. He had been at a friend's house the entire day. The mother eventually apologised. But the accusation — and the three hours of having no proof — stayed with Sipho long after.

"I just want to do it properly. With the right tools. So that everyone — the parents, the children, me — everyone feels safe and respected. That is all I want." — Sipho M., research participant

Driver Research Findings

Finding 1 Informal drivers absorb financial losses from poor parent communication because there is no formal system requiring advance notice. Every unnecessary trip costs the driver fuel and time directly out of their own pocket.

Finding 2 Parents unconsciously treat informal transport as a favour rather than a professional service. That dynamic shifts completely when a company structure exists behind the service.

Finding 3 The accountability gap affects children's behaviour too. When children know there is no tracking system they learn to exploit that gap. A confirmation system closes a behavioural loophole that children naturally discover.

Finding 4 Drivers want to be tracked. Not because they are forced to but because it protects them. Accountability cuts both ways — the same system that reassures parents is the same data that clears a driver of a false accusation.

Finding 5 The driver interface must be fast and minimal. No complexity. Clear and quick. Every extra decision the app requires during driving is a direct safety risk to the children in the car.

Finding 6 Route information stored in the system enables backup drivers. If a driver is sick or unavailable a replacement can run the route without starting from zero. This emerged purely from research — nobody planned for it.

Finding 7 The system is the witness. A driver doing everything correctly has no way to prove it without a formal record. Timestamped confirmations transform the app from a convenience tool into a legal protection layer.

Finding 8 GPS should trigger the confirmation screen automatically. When the driver arrives at a school the app detects the location and surfaces only the children assigned to that school. The driver should never have to navigate or search. The app does the organising.

Finding 9 Automated parent notifications remove the communication burden from the driver completely. The driver's job is to drive. The app's job is to communicate. Separating those two responsibilities makes both better.

Finding 10 Cognitive load during driving must be near zero. Three seconds maximum screen interaction per stop. Any more than that is a safety risk and a design failure.

Finding 11 Driver profile visibility before arrival transforms a stranger into a known and trusted person before the first pickup. Name, photo, and car registration visible to the parent on the app before the car even arrives at the door.

Finding 12 A trip rating system builds official driver reputation beyond word of mouth. Good drivers deserve a formal record of their performance. It protects quality drivers and surfaces problematic ones for the company.

Finding 13 Incident reporting gives drivers a formal channel to document in-car safety issues. Protects the driver, the child, and the company simultaneously. Right now drivers report verbally and are either believed or not with no record either way.

Cross Interview Insight

One insight emerged independently from both participants without either knowing the other existed.

Nomsa described sitting at work with her phone off not knowing if her children arrived safely. Siphso described having no record to show a mother who accused him of not doing his job.

Both participants are describing the same gap from opposite sides.

The parent has no visibility. The driver has no proof. The same feature solves both problems simultaneously.

That is not a coincidence. That is the core product insight of Fika confirmed by independent research.

Synthesis

Step 1 — Capture

All 21 findings from both interviews laid out flat. Parent findings 1 through 8 covering word of mouth limitations, informal distrust, affordability, institutional accountability, reliability, legal protection, arrival notification, and feeling like a good parent. Driver findings 1 through 13 covering financial loss from absences, favour versus professional service, children exploiting accountability gaps, drivers wanting to be tracked, minimal interface requirements, backup drivers, system as witness, GPS triggered confirmations, automated notifications, cognitive load, driver profile visibility, trip ratings, and incident reporting.

Step 2 — Cluster

Cluster 1 — Trust and Accountability Parent Findings 2, 4, 6 — Driver Findings 2, 4, 7, 11

Parents do not trust individuals without formal structure behind them. Drivers want to be tracked because it protects them. Legal accountability matters to both sides. Driver profile visibility builds trust before the first pickup.

Pattern: Trust is not assumed. It is built through structure, visibility, and formal accountability on both sides.

Cluster 2 — Communication Breakdown Parent Findings 1, 5, 7 — Driver Findings 1, 9

Word of mouth has geographic limits. Reliability breaks when communication is informal. Arrival notifications would transform a parent's morning. Drivers lose income because parents do not notify absences. Automated notifications remove communication burden from the driver.

Pattern: Every pain point in this product traces back to a communication gap between parent and driver. The app's primary job is to close that gap automatically.

Cluster 3 — Safety and Protection Parent Findings 3, 6, 8 — Driver Findings 3, 7, 12, 13

Affordability determines access to safety. Legal protection matters when things go wrong. Fika sells the feeling of being a good parent. Children exploit gaps in accountability. The system as witness protects drivers. Ratings and incident reports protect everyone.

Pattern: Safety means something different to each user. For parents it is emotional. For drivers it is legal. The app must serve both definitions simultaneously.

Cluster 4 — Operational Efficiency Driver Findings 5, 6, 8, 9, 10

Driver interface must be fast and minimal. Route data enables backup drivers. GPS triggers confirmation screens. Automated notifications handle communication. Cognitive load must be near zero.

Pattern: The driver interface is a safety critical tool. Every second of unnecessary interaction is a risk. Efficiency is not a convenience feature — it is a child protection feature.

Cluster 5 — Emotional Value Parent Findings 7, 8 — Driver Findings 4, 11

One notification transforms a parent's entire morning. Fika sells the feeling of being a good parent. Drivers want to feel respected and protected. Profile visibility humanises the driver before arrival.

Pattern: Both users need to feel something from this app — not just use it. The emotional experience is the product.

Step 3 — Insight Generation

Insight 1 — Trust is infrastructure Parents and drivers both arrive at Fika already suspicious of each other. The app cannot assume goodwill exists at the start. It has to build trust actively through visible structure, vetted profiles, and formal accountability before the first trip even happens.

Insight 2 — The app is the communication layer Every breakdown in the current informal system happens because communication depends on humans remembering to do something. The app must remove human memory from the equation entirely. Notifications, confirmations, and absence alerts must happen automatically — not because someone remembered to send them.

Insight 3 — Safety has two currencies For parents safety is emotional — the feeling that their child is protected. For drivers safety is legal — the proof that they did their job correctly. Fika must pay both currencies with every interaction. A confirmation tap is not just a notification to the parent. It is a legal timestamp for the driver.

Insight 4 — The driver interface is a safety critical tool This is not a consumer app where a slow screen is mildly annoying. A driver distracted by a complicated interface has children in the car. Three seconds maximum interaction per stop is not a design preference. It is a child protection requirement.

Insight 5 — Fika sells relief not transport Nobody opens Fika because they love the idea of a school transport app. They open it because they are afraid. The product exists to convert that fear into relief — one confirmed arrival at a time. Every screen, every notification, every interaction must be measured against whether it moves the parent from afraid to relieved.

Step 4 — How Might We Questions

From Insight 1 — Trust is infrastructure

Surface: How might we show a parent everything they need to trust their driver before the first pickup arrives?

Structural: How might we design an onboarding experience that builds institutional trust before a parent ever meets their driver in person?

Deep: How might we create a product that makes a parent feel safer trusting a vetted company than trusting a neighbour they have known for years?

From Insight 2 — The app is the communication layer

Surface: How might we ensure a parent receives an arrival notification without the driver having to remember to send one?

Structural: How might we design an absence notification system that makes it easier for a parent to notify than to forget?

Deep: How might we remove human memory entirely from the communication chain between parent and driver?

From Insight 3 — Safety has two currencies

Surface: How might we design a confirmation tap that simultaneously reassures the parent and protects the driver?

Structural: How might we build a record system that a driver can reference as legal evidence if an accusation is made?

Deep: How might we design an app where every single interaction serves both the parent's emotional need and the driver's legal need at the same time?

From Insight 4 — The driver interface is a safety critical tool

Surface: How might we design a confirmation screen that a driver can complete in under three seconds without taking their eyes off the road?

Structural: How might we use GPS to do the organising so the driver only has to confirm — never to navigate the app?

Deep: How might we design a driver interface where the app thinks ahead so the driver never has to?

From Insight 5 — Fika sells relief not transport

Surface: How might we design an arrival notification that feels warm and human rather than like a system message?

Structural: How might we design the tracking screen so that watching the car move converts anxiety into calm in real time?

Deep: How might we design an entire product experience that makes a parent feel like a good parent every single school morning regardless of whether they can be there in person?

Persona 1 — Nomsa D., Parent

Name: Nomsa D. Role: Parent Persona — Fika App Age: 34 Occupation: Admin clerk, Bellville, Cape Town Device: Android user Household: Single income, two children

Quote: "It would make me feel like a better mother. Like I did something right for my children even though I cannot be there with them."

Day starts 5:30 — Children 2 — Leaves for work 7:00 — First phone check 12:30

Goals: Know both children arrived safely without having to call and wait for a reply. Feel like a responsible mother even when she cannot be physically present. Have someone she can hold accountable if something goes wrong — not just a neighbour's word.

Frustrations: Sitting at her desk with her phone off, not knowing if they got there. Informal drivers offer no contract, no insurance, no recourse. Word of mouth referrals do not cross neighbourhoods. Communication depends entirely on a 9 year old and a 14 year old remembering to call.

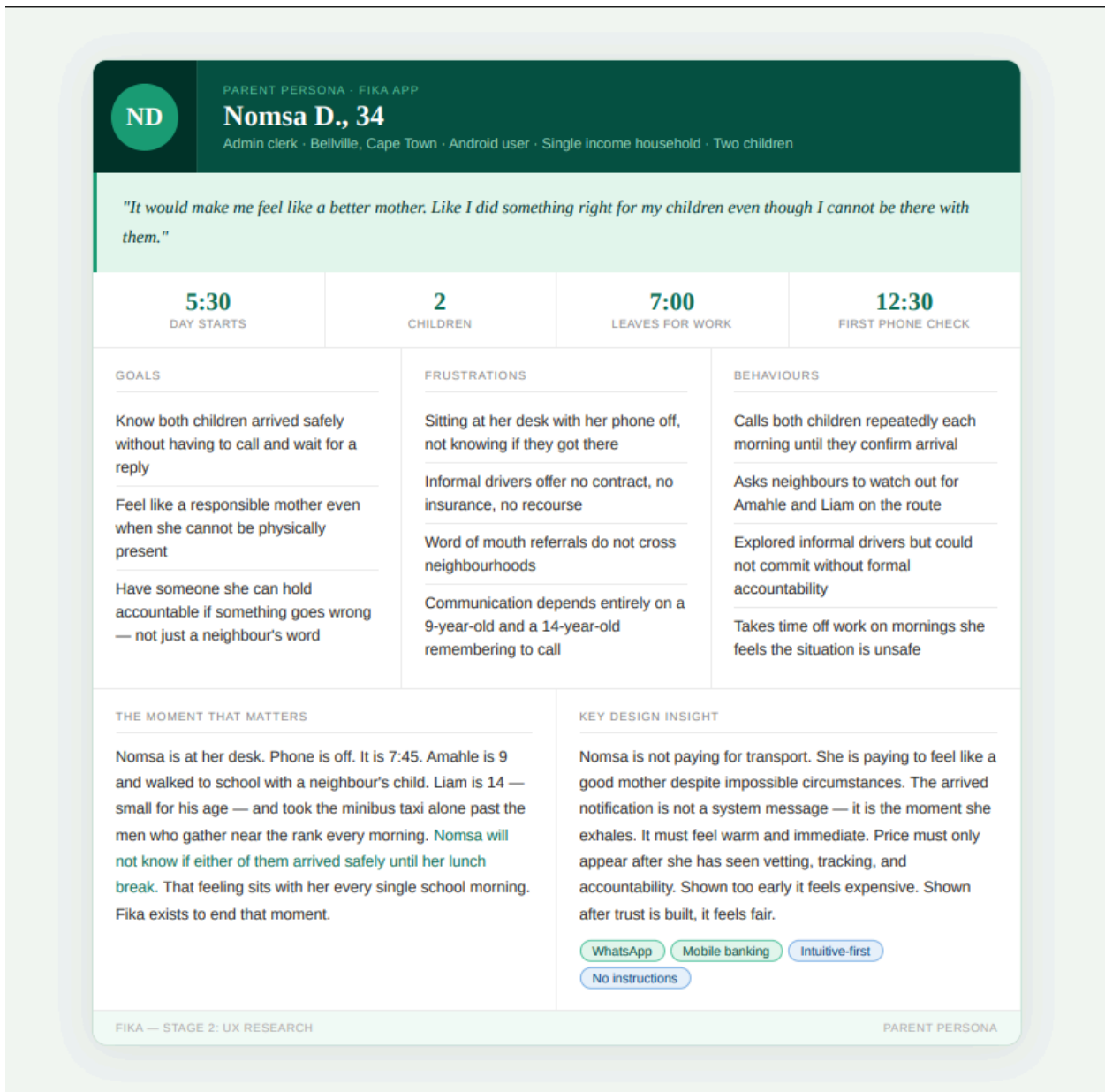
Behaviours: Calls both children repeatedly each morning until they confirm arrival. Asks neighbours to watch out for Amahle and Liam on the route. Explored informal drivers but could not commit without formal accountability. Takes time off work on mornings she feels the situation is unsafe.

The moment that matters: Nomsa is at her desk. Phone is off. It is 7:45. Amahle is 9 and walked to school with a neighbour's child. Liam is 14 — small for his age — and took the minibus taxi alone past the men who gather near the rank every morning. Nomsa will not know if either of

them arrived safely until her lunch break. That feeling sits with her every single school morning. Fika exists to end that moment.

Key design insight: Nomsa is not paying for transport. She is paying to feel like a good mother despite impossible circumstances. The arrived notification is not a system message — it is the moment she exhales. It must feel warm and immediate. Price must only appear after she has seen vetting, tracking, and accountability. Shown too early it feels expensive. Shown after trust is built, it feels fair.

Apps: WhatsApp, Mobile banking — Intuitive first, no instructions



Persona 2 — Sipho M., Driver

Name: Sipho M. Role: Driver Persona — Fika App Age: 29 Occupation: Informal school transport driver, Brackenfell, Cape Town Vehicle: 2018 Toyota Corolla, owner-operator Experience: 2 years

Quote: "I just want to do it properly. With the right tools. So that everyone — the parents, the children, me — everyone feels safe and respected. That is all I want."

Day starts 5:45 — Children 6 — Schools 3 — Max screen time 3 seconds

Goals: A verifiable record of every drop-off he can point to if something goes wrong. Absence alerts before he leaves, not after he has made the trip. The app handles parent communication — he handles the driving.

Frustrations: Accused without evidence and no way to defend himself. Parents who know a child is absent but stay silent until he arrives. Wasted fuel on trips he cannot recover.

Behaviours: Plans the full route the night before — no time to think in the morning. Waits 2 to 4 minutes per drop to watch each child go inside. Takes personal screenshots to protect himself when things go wrong.

The moment that matters: Sipho dropped Kavelo at school and watched him walk through the gate. That afternoon, the mother called — the school said he was never in class. She accused Sipho of not bringing him. For three hours, Sipho had nothing to show her. No timestamp. No record. Kavelo had left through a hole in the fence. The mother apologised — but the three hours without proof stayed with Sipho long after. This is not hypothetical. This already happened.

Key design insight: Sipho does not resist being tracked — he wants it. The same data that reassures a parent is the same data that clears him of a false accusation. Every interaction on his interface must be completable in under 3 seconds. Children are in the car. Anything longer is a safety risk, not just a UX problem.

Apps: WhatsApp, Google Maps — Comfortable with tech, eyes-free priority



FIKA — Stage 3: Problem Framing and Information Architecture

Refined Problem Statement

Cape Town parents of primary and high school learners struggle to trust their children's safety travelling to and from school — because there is no affordable, child-only, trustworthy transport solution that gives them real visibility into whether their child arrived safely. The current informal system offers no safety assurance for drivers, no protection when parents act out of fear or

emotion, and no structured communication channel between parents and drivers when something unexpected happens. It also creates a road safety risk when drivers navigate unfamiliar routes while children are in the car.

User Journey Map — Nomsa D. (Parent)

Current state journey. Before Fika exists.

Stage 1 — Morning Preparation (5:30 – 6:00) Action: Wakes up and prepares herself before the children wake up so the morning runs smoothly. Thought: I need to be ready before them or nothing gets done. Emotion: Tired but focused. Opportunity: None at this stage — Fika does not intervene here.

Stage 2 — Getting Children Ready (6:00 – 6:50) Action: Wakes both children, makes sure they eat, checks their bags and uniforms. Chases Liam who is slow in the morning — typical teenage behaviour. Thought: Will they make it in time. Liam is always slow. Emotion: Stressed and rushing. Opportunity: None at this stage — this is domestic preparation before transport begins.

Stage 3 — Sending Children Off (6:50 – 7:00) Action: Makes sure both children leave the house before she does. Amahle walks with a neighbour's child. Liam heads to the taxi rank alone. Thought: Are they really going to be okay out there. What if something happens after I leave. Emotion: Anxious. Guilt beginning to build. Opportunity: Fika pickup notification — parent receives confirmation the moment the driver arrives and the child gets in the car.

Stage 4 — Commute to Work (7:00 – 7:15) Action: Catches her taxi to work. Phone is still on but she cannot focus on anything else. Thought: Did Amahle get there safely. Did Liam get past those men near the rank. Did he get on the right taxi. Emotion: Worried, helpless, distracted. Opportunity: Live tracking — Nomsa can open Fika on her commute and watch the car moving toward the school in real time.

Stage 5 — At Work, Phone Off (7:15 – lunch) Action: Works with phone switched off. Sneaks to the bathroom during the morning to check her phone and see if the children have messaged. Thought: I just need to know they are safe. Why is there no way to know this without bothering them. Emotion: Peak anxiety. Guilt. Distracted from work. Opportunity: Arrived notification — automatically sent the moment the driver confirms drop-off at school. Nomsa receives it without having to check, call, or sneak to the bathroom.

Stage 6 — First Confirmation (lunch break) Action: Checks phone at lunch. Calls or messages both children hoping they answer. Thought: Please just answer. Are they okay. Emotion: Relief only if they answer. Continued anxiety if they do not. Opportunity: This stage becomes unnecessary with Fika. The arrived notification in Stage 5 already resolved her anxiety hours earlier.

User Journey Map — Sipho M. (Driver)

Current state journey. Before Fika exists.

Stage 1 — Night Before Route (previous evening) Action: Plans his full route, memorises all addresses and the order of schools based on start times. Thought: I have to get this right tonight or the morning will fall apart. Emotion: Focused but carrying the full mental load alone with no system to support him. Opportunity: Fika manifest — route, addresses, school times, and confirmed children all loaded automatically. No manual planning required.

Stage 2 — Morning Preparation (5:45) Action: Wakes up, gets ready, prepares the car for the route. Thought: Who is actually coming today. Did anyone notify me about absences last night. Emotion: Uncertain. Already anticipating problems before the route has started. Opportunity: Absence notifications — any parent who marked a child absent the night before or early morning is already reflected in today's manifest before Sipho leaves home.

Stage 3 — Pickups (6:00 – 7:00) Action: Drives to each house in route order. Hoots and waits for each child to come out. Thought: Why is this child not ready. Why did nobody tell me she is absent. I am wasting fuel and time. I have other children waiting. Emotion: Frustrated. Disrespected. Financially anxious. Feels like he is doing a favour rather than providing a professional service. Opportunity: Confirmed manifest — Sipho sees exactly who is coming before he leaves. No unnecessary trips. Popup notification at each house confirms the pickup with a timestamp the moment he taps Picked Up.

Stage 4 — Driving to Schools (7:00 – 7:30) Action: Drives with all children in the car. Manages behaviour inside the vehicle while navigating to the first school. Thought: I need to get there on time. Are the children safe in the car. What if I am late for the first school. Emotion: Stressed. Responsible. Fully focused on the road. Opportunity: GPS navigation built into the active route screen. Familiar schools loaded automatically. New routes pre-loaded so the driver never navigates an unfamiliar school while children are in the car.

Stage 5 — Drop-offs (7:15 – 7:45) Action: Arrives at each school. Watches each child walk through the gate before driving to the next school. Thought: Did they go inside. Will they stay inside. I have no way to know what happens after I drive away. Emotion: Partially relieved but not fully settled. The responsibility feels unresolved. Opportunity: GPS triggered drop-off confirmation — the app detects school arrival automatically and surfaces only the children assigned to that school. Sipho taps Dropped Off. Timestamp saved. Parent notified instantly.

Stage 6 — After Drop-off (7:45+) Action: Drives home after the last school. No confirmation system exists. He carries the weight of the morning with him. Thought: I hope nobody calls saying a child is missing. I have nothing to show if they do. I wish there was a platform that helped me with this. Emotion: Lingering anxiety. Unprotected. The three hours of the Kavelo situation live in his memory every single day. Opportunity: Timestamped trip records stored

automatically in Fika. Every pickup, every drop-off, every route logged. Sipho's legal protection sitting in the system whether he needs it or not.

Information Architecture — Parent App

Five main sections. Every action Nomsa needs has a clear home.

- 1. Onboarding** Register account, add children and school details, select area, submit application, await company approval. This section is completed once and not revisited unless a new child is added.
 - 2. Home Dashboard** The first screen Nomsa sees every time she opens Fika. Live trip status, active driver information including name, photo, and plate number, pickup notification, drop-off notification, absence notification shortcut, and quick access to the tracking screen.
 - 3. Tracking** Full live map view, real-time driver location, route progress, and estimated arrival time. Accessed by tapping the active trip card on the Home Dashboard. This is the screen Nomsa watches on her commute to work.
 - 4. My Children** Child profiles, school details, trip schedule for morning and afternoon, and the absence notification feature where a parent marks a child as not attending today before the driver leaves for the route.
 - 5. Account** Monthly payment management, account settings, and complaint and report filing.
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Information Architecture — Driver App

Four main sections. Built entirely from what research revealed Sipho needs.

- 1. Home — Shift Dashboard** The first screen Sipho sees when he opens the app. Driver profile, start shift button, shift summary showing how many children are confirmed today, which schools, and what time the first pickup must happen.
- 2. Client Screen — Today's Manifest** Full list of all children assigned to today's route. Who is confirmed coming, who has been marked absent by their parent, pickup addresses in route order, school assignments, and school start times so Sipho knows who to prioritise first.
- 3. Active Route — Tracking and Confirmations** GPS navigation to each pickup address and school in route order. Popup notification at each house — driver taps Picked Up, timestamp saved, parent notified. Popup notification at each school — app detects location automatically and surfaces only the children for that school — driver taps Dropped Off, timestamp saved, all relevant parents notified simultaneously.

4. Reports File incident reports, log complaints, and view the full history of past trip records with timestamps. This is Sipho's legal protection layer — every trip documented, every confirmation stored, accessible any time an accusation is made.

The Core IA Insight

The parent's tracking screen and the driver's active route screen are powered by the same live data. The parent sees the car moving toward the school. The driver generates that movement. One data source. Two interfaces. Two users served simultaneously.

This is not a coincidence of design. It is the direct result of the research insight identified in Stage 2: the parent has no visibility, the driver has no proof, and the same feature resolves both problems at once.

FIKA — Stage 4: High-Fidelity Screens

All 25 screens — 12 parent-facing, 13 driver-facing — were built in Figma on a single design system, so both interfaces feel like one coherent product even though they serve two very different jobs to be done: one built for reassurance, the other built for speed and protection under real driving conditions.

Design System

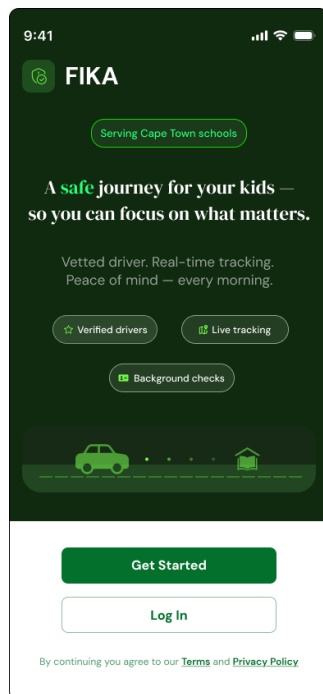
Colour. Background white. Deep forest green (#0F2A0F) as the primary brand colour. A lighter accent green for secondary elements. Dark green is reserved for primary call-to-action buttons only, following the 60-30-10 rule — so the one action that matters most on each screen always stands out clearly from the rest of the interface.

Typography. DM Serif Display for headlines only, bold, 28–32px — chosen to give Fika warmth against what is otherwise a highly functional, safety-critical app. DM Sans for everything else: body copy, labels, and buttons, chosen for clarity and legibility at small sizes.

Consistent components. A back arrow in the top left on every screen. A green progress bar on all onboarding screens, paired with a step indicator (Step 1 of 3, Step 2 of 3, Step 3 of 3). A Fika shield logomark — a parent and child inside a shield outline — paired with the FIKA wordmark throughout.

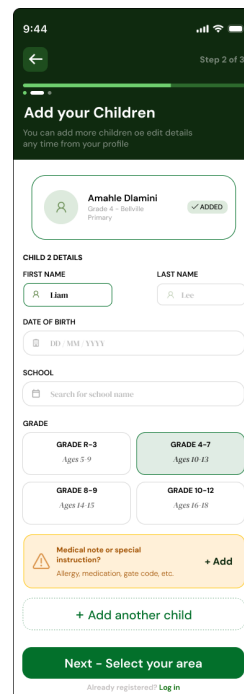
Four parent screens and four driver screens are shown below — a working sample from the full set of 25, selected to show the emotional and functional arc of each interface from first open to resolution.

Parent Screens



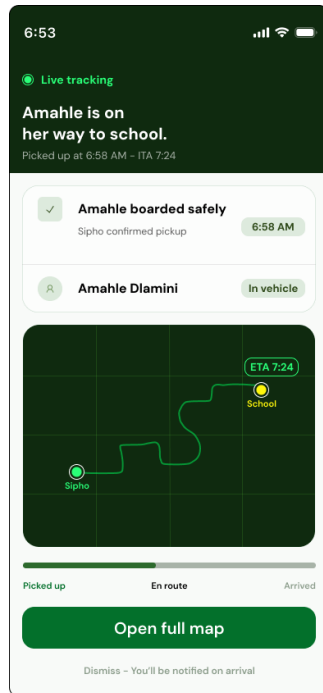
Welcome

Trust badges up front — verified drivers, live tracking, background checks — before a parent is asked for anything.



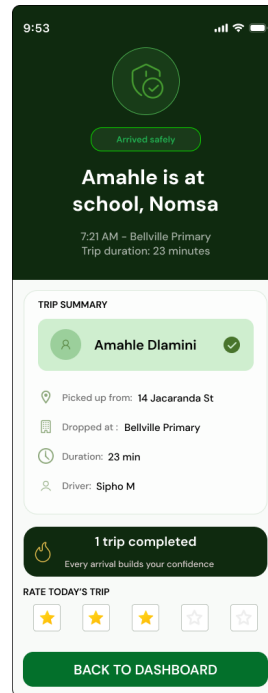
Add Child Profile

One committed step at a time. Guards against the Paradox of Choice — an anxious parent won't finish a form asking everything at once.



Live Tracking

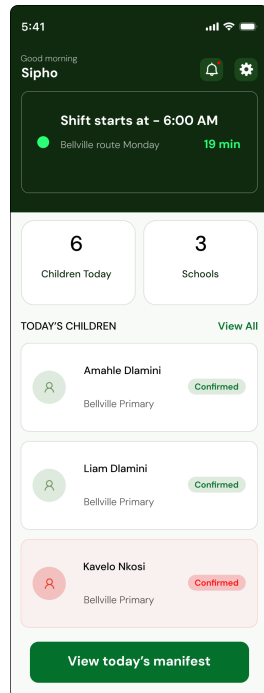
The moving dot Nomsa watches on her commute. Familiar Uber/Bolt mental model, on purpose — no learning curve during an anxious moment.



Arrived

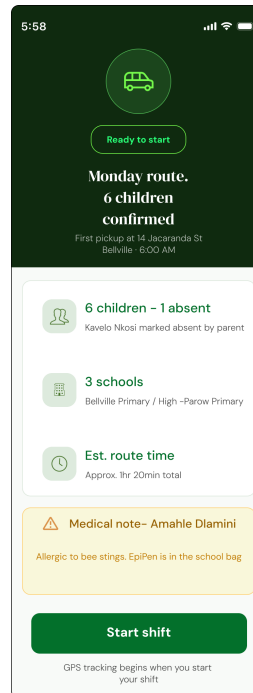
The Peak End Rule payoff. This is the moment a parent exhales — it has to feel warm, not like a system message.

Driver Screens



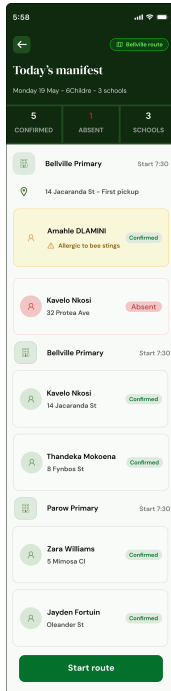
Shift Dashboard

Siphon sees who's confirmed and who's absent before he even leaves home — no surprises discovered on arrival.



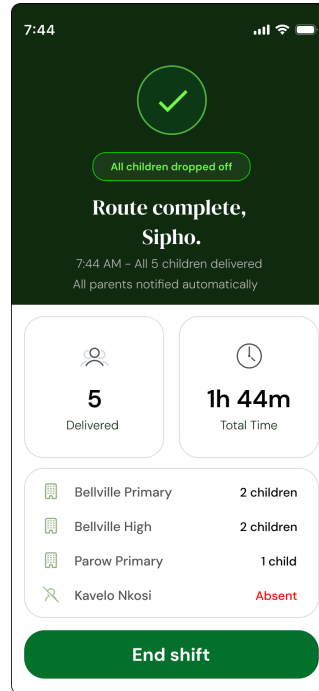
Start Shift

Medical notes surface using the Von Restorff Effect — Amahle's allergy note visually separates from routine information.



Today's Manifest

Confirmed, absent, and by-school grouping in one scroll — Sipho never has to search or guess who's coming.



Route Complete

Every drop-off, timestamped, all parents already notified. This is Sipho's protection — the system as witness.

What's Next

Two stages remain, and they are sequenced deliberately rather than skipped.

Stage 5 — Usability Testing (not yet run)

Testing a partial interface risks surfacing problems that a completed information architecture would have already resolved on its own. All 25 screens across both interfaces were only just finished, so priority went into completing full coverage first — testing comes next, against a whole product rather than fragments of one.

The test plan itself was written back in Stage 1, before a single screen existed:

- **Registration:** Can a first-time parent complete registration without confusion or abandonment?
- **Tracking:** Does the parent feel reassured the moment they see the tracking screen?
- **Driver route:** Can a driver complete pickups, navigation, and confirmations without looking at the screen for more than 3 seconds at a time?
- **Arrival:** Does the arrived notification land as warm and trustworthy, or cold and robotic?

Stage 6 — Strategic Leadership Thinking (following testing)

This final stage connects Fika's design decisions to business outcomes — the monetisation model, what actually drives retention, and how a trust-building product like this creates defensible value for a transport company rather than just a pleasant user experience. It is sequenced after usability testing on purpose: real user feedback should inform which business risks get prioritised first, not the other way around.